

Networked Rivalries, Enemy Image, and Public Resistance to Peace: Evidence from East Asia

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Abstract

Under what international conditions do citizens support or resist peace with a foreign adversary? Existing research emphasizes reciprocal cooperation between rival states and the dyad-specific conditions that shape how citizens interpret cooperative signals. Yet peace initiatives unfold within a broader security environment in which publics also observe allies and other adversaries as politically relevant actors. This article argues that third-party rivalries involving allied and adversarial states shape attitudes toward peace by altering the enemy image of the focal rival. Intensified hostility in these rivalries heightens perceptions of intergroup confrontation, reinforces ally-enemy boundaries, and increases resistance to rapprochement. I test this argument using original observational and experimental data from East Asian rivalry contexts. First, text analysis of over one million tweets from South Korea and Japan shows that U.S.-North Korea conflict is associated with stronger anti-North Korean sentiment in South Korea and more negative views of China in Japan. Second, a survey experiment demonstrates that exposure to conflicts in the Japan-China and inter-Korean rivalries reinforces Americans' hostility toward China and reduces support for cooperation. Together, these findings demonstrate that public perceptions of adversaries and peace are embedded in networked rivalries in East Asia.

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Introduction

Presidents Roh Moo-hyun and Moon Jae-in, close political allies in South Korea's liberal camp, both prioritized dialogue with Pyongyang and pursued reconciliation through high-level inter-Korean summits. Roh's engagement policy culminated in his 2007 meeting with Kim Jong-il in Pyongyang, while Moon advanced a similar initiative more than a decade later through multiple summits with Kim Jong-un in 2018. In both cases, North Korea agreed to denuclearization and the reduction of military tensions, signaling a renewed atmosphere of inter-Korean engagement. Yet public responses to these two peace initiatives differed sharply. Roh's dovish policies faced widespread skepticism. In 2007, only 10.9% approved of his conciliatory policy toward North Korea ([The Hankyoreh, 2007](#)), while a large majority of South Koreans (91.1%) continued to distrust the North Korean regime ([B. Kim et al., 2007](#)). By contrast, Moon's conciliatory approach received broad public support. In 2018, 64.4% of South Koreans supported Moon's North Korea policy, coinciding with a marked shift in public attitudes toward the North: a majority trusted North Korea's regime (54.7%), and viewed it as a partner for cooperation or support (54.6%) ([Jung et al., 2018](#)). This stronger domestic backing helped make Moon's rapprochement appear more politically sustainable than Roh's earlier engagement effort.

These divergent public responses in South Korea are puzzling from the perspective of existing research, which has largely focused on the roles of reciprocal cooperation within a rivalry dyad. In this view, an adversary's positive response to conciliatory gestures can soften citizens' negative perceptions of a rival state, thereby reducing the domestic backlash leaders face for advocating peace ([Colaresi, 2004](#); [Kupchan, 2010](#)). A growing body of work further shows that the effects of cooperative signals depend on their credibility ([Kydd, 2005](#); [Kertzer et al., 2020](#); [S. J. Kim, 2021](#); [Yoder & Haynes, 2021](#)), the reputations of the elites who send or elicit them ([Mattes & Weeks, 2019, 2022](#)), and the dispositions of the publics who interpret them ([Kertzer et al., 2020](#); [Fu & Lee, 2024](#); [Han, 2025](#)). These studies offer important insights, but they remain centered on bilateral interactions

between rival states. Publics encounter peace initiatives within a broader information environment: through news media and political discourse, they observe not only their own state's rivalry, but also conflict and cooperation among other adversaries, allies, and regional actors. Also, the South Korean case underscores this limitation: Roh and Moon shared many political characteristics as liberal leaders, and their initiatives produced comparable cooperative outcomes from North Korea, yet public reactions differed markedly. This variation points to the need to examine how citizens evaluate rapprochement not only through direct exchanges, but also through the broader security environment in which the focal rivalry is embedded.

This paper fills this gap by exploring how the interdependence of international rivalries shapes public opinion on peace with a foreign adversary. It builds on a growing literature that views international rivalries not as isolated bilateral contests, but as relationships embedded in broader networks of allies and enemies. Although early quantitative conflict research placed dyadic interactions at the center of analysis ([De Mesquita, 1983](#); [Bremer, 1992](#)), recent work shows that international outcomes are jointly shaped by interactions across multiple interstate relationships ([Poast, 2016](#); [Cranmer & Desmarais, 2016](#)). A similar shift has occurred in rivalry scholarship: whereas previous studies treated conflict dynamics as largely internal to rivalry dyads ([Leng, 2000](#); [Diehl & Goertz, 2001](#)), a growing body of work drawing on structural balance theory demonstrates that rivalry dynamics unfold within interdependent networks, where changes in one dyad can reshape patterns of alignment and confrontation across related dyads ([Goldstein & Freeman, 1990](#); [Goldstein & Pevehouse, 1997](#); [Maoz et al., 2007](#); [Akcinaroglu et al., 2014](#); [B. K. Lee, 2022](#); [Mehrl et al., 2025](#); [Yoder & Cohen, 2025](#)). Building on these insights, this paper examines the effects of third-party rivalries—rivalries in which at least one state actor lies outside the focal rivalry dyad—as extra-dyadic cues through which publics perceive foreign actors. That is, rather than viewing public attitudes toward peace as shaped only by direct interactions between one's own state and its adversary, this networked approach posits that citizens evaluate foreign adversaries and conciliatory policies within a broader international environment structured by interconnected rivalries.

In this paper, I argue that perceived hostility in third-party rivalries between allies and adversaries can heighten public resistance to peace by sharpening the focal rival's enemy image. National images serve as cognitive shortcuts that help citizens make sense of complex international environments and form foreign policy attitudes (Jervis, 1976; Hurwitz & Peffley, 1990). In rivalry contexts, these images are often organized around an ally-enemy distinction: states perceived as threatening or as pursuing incompatible goals are viewed as adversaries, whereas states seen as providing security benefits or sharing compatible goals are viewed as allies (Boulding, 1956; Cottam, 1977; Herrmann & Fischerkeller, 1995). Yet citizens do not form these images only through direct interactions with the focal rival. Individuals often interpret political events through group boundaries separating in-groups from out-groups (Tajfel, 1981; Turner & Oakes, 1986), and conflict across these boundaries can make group identities more salient by strengthening attachment to the in-group and intensifying negative evaluations of the out-group (Hogg, 1992; Gibler et al., 2012). Applied to international politics, this logic implies that hostility in third-party rivalries crossing perceived ally-enemy groups can be interpreted not as an isolated bilateral dispute, but as extra-dyadic cues of broader intergroup confrontation. Then, such perceptions can sharpen the enemy image of the focal rival by reaffirming its membership in the enemy camp, thereby reinforcing resistance to reconciliation. I distinguish between two forms of this process: overlapping rivalries, in which the focal rival directly confronts an allied state, and parallel rivalries, in which an allied state confronts another perceived enemy. In both cases, conflict in third-party rivalries can heighten ally-enemy polarization and reduce public support for peace.

I test this argument using two empirical studies from East Asia, a region where international rivalries are embedded in a dense network of allies and adversaries. Study I analyzes over one million tweets from South Korea and Japan between 2017 and 2018, a period in which U.S.-North Korea relations shifted dramatically from acute military tension to high-profile summit diplomacy. This setting allows me to examine two forms of third-party rivalry: for South Koreans, U.S.-North Korea relations constitute an overlapping rivalry because the focal rival, North Korea, is directly

involved; for Japanese citizens, the same rivalry constitutes a parallel rivalry because it does not directly involve the focal rival, China, but unfolds within the same regional security network. Using supervised machine-learning models, I estimate the probability that each tweet expresses either an enemy image of the focal rival or anti-dove backlash against domestic actors favoring conciliation. The results show that, even after controlling for conflict within the focal bilateral rivalry, heightened U.S.-DPRK conflict is associated with stronger anti-North Korean sentiment in South Korea and more negative views of China in Japan.

Study II provides a causal test through a pre-registered survey experiment in the United States. In this study, respondents were randomly assigned to view news video clips depicting either conflict or cooperation in one of two East Asian rivalries: the Japan-China rivalry, which represents an overlapping rivalry for Americans evaluating China, or the inter-Korean rivalry, which represents a parallel rivalry. The results show that exposure to Japan-China conflict reinforces Americans' negative perceptions of China. The treatment also polarizes broader national images, making U.S. allies such as Japan and South Korea appear more favorable and adversarial states such as China and North Korea appear more threatening. Exposure to inter-Korean conflict produces a similar but weaker pattern, including more negative perceptions of China and broader polarization in Americans' images of allies and adversaries in East Asia. Finally, the results suggest that both overlapping and parallel third-party rivalry conflict can increase American opposition to conciliatory policies toward China, although some effects are only suggestive.

The article proceeds as follows. I first review existing research on public opinion toward peace with foreign adversaries, highlighting its emphasis on cooperative signaling within rivalry dyads. I then develop a networked perspective, arguing that citizens evaluate rapprochement not only through interactions with the focal adversary, but also through those in third-party rivalries. Next, I specify the microfoundations of this argument and derive hypotheses about how extra-dyadic rivalries shape enemy images and public opposition to peace. I then test these expectations using original Twitter data from South Korea and Japan and a survey experiment in the United States.

Finally, I conclude with implications for theory and policy.

Public Opinion on Peace beyond Dyadic Rivalries

State leaders may struggle to sustain peace initiatives with foreign adversaries when rapprochement lacks public approval. Public support is politically consequential in several respects, particularly in democratic contexts. First, it helps leaders defend conciliatory policies against hawkish opponents and preserve the domestic political standing needed for reconciliation ([Vasquez, 1993](#); [Colaresi, 2004](#)). Second, it strengthens the credibility of peace: without public backing, foreign counterparts may doubt whether accommodation can survive future political opposition or leadership turnover ([Brandt et al., 2008](#)). Lastly, elite-level agreements may remain fragile unless they become embedded in broader societal support for reconciliation ([Kupchan, 2010](#); [Ripsman, 2016](#)).

What, then, accounts for public opinion on peace with a foreign adversary? Existing studies have largely answered this question by focusing on interactions within rivalry dyads, especially the exchange of cooperative signals between adversarial states. In this view, an adversary's positive response to a conciliatory gesture allows citizens to update their beliefs about the rival's intentions, softening negative perceptions and reducing domestic backlash against leaders who pursue rapprochement ([Kupchan, 2010](#); [Colaresi, 2004](#)). Empirical studies support this logic, showing that adversary cooperation can increase public support for conciliatory policies and strengthen support for leaders who pursue them ([Davies & Johns, 2016](#); [Mattes & Weeks, 2019](#)). Beyond the presence of cooperation itself, scholars also emphasize that the credibility of these signals shape public responses. Drawing on strategic signaling theory ([Schelling, 1960](#); [Jervis, 1970](#)), this work argues that cooperative gestures are especially persuasive when they entail material, political, or strategic costs ([Kydd, 2005](#)). Consistent with this logic, recent experimental studies show that costly reassuring signals—such as larger Russian military withdrawals from the Arctic ([Mattes & Weeks, 2022](#)) and Iran's acceptance of stricter nuclear inspections and fuel-cycle restrictions ([Kertzer et](#)

al., 2020)—can increase trust and support for cooperation.

At the same time, existing research shows that observing an adversary's benign gesture does not always translate into public support for peace. Much of this work explains such limits by focusing on factors within the rivalry dyad that condition how citizens respond to cooperative signals. When the counterpart is firmly viewed as an enemy, distrust and negativity bias can weaken the persuasive effect of even costly cooperation. Experimental evidence shows that cooperative gestures may fail under low baseline trust (Yoder & Haynes, 2021), and benign actions often have weaker perceptual effects than similarly costly hostile ones (Kim, 2021). Elite cues and political reputations matter as well: dovish leaders receive fewer public approval from reciprocated cooperation than hawks (Mattes & Weeks, 2019), while public support declines when the adversary's leader is perceived as hawkish (Mattes & Weeks, 2022). Additionally, individual predispositions condition responses to cooperation. Costly cooperation showed weaker effects among Americans with lower cooperative internationalism in the U.S.-Iran context (Kertzer et al., 2020); North Korean cooperation during the 2018 inter-Korean rapprochement failed to increase support for peace among South Koreans who did not view North Korea as co-ethnic (Han, 2025); and China's costly reassuring signals toward Taiwan increased trust only in non-crisis settings, particularly among dovish individuals (Fu & Lee, 2024).

Despite these important insights, this literature remains largely dyadic in focus. This limited scope contrasts with a broader shift in IR scholarship that increasingly challenges the assumption that interstate politics can be understood through isolated bilateral relationships. Although early quantitative conflict research placed dyadic interactions at the center of analysis (De Mesquita, 1983; Bremer, 1992), subsequent work shows that interactions across multiple relationships jointly shape international outcomes (Poast, 2016; Cranmer & Desmarais, 2016). Specifically, reducing inherently multilateral processes—such as alliance formation, extended deterrence, and war expansion—to dyadic units can therefore produce theoretical and empirical misspecification (Croco & Teo, 2005; Poast, 2010; Fordham & Poast, 2016). The same concern applies to public opin-

ion on peace. Existing studies explain attitudes toward rapprochement primarily as responses to de-escalation within the focal rivalry: whether an adversary reciprocates cooperation, how costly its signal is, and which dyad-specific factors condition its effect. This focus leaves open how citizens interpret peace within a broader information environment. Through news media and political discourse, publics are exposed not only to their own state's rivalry but also to conflict and cooperation among other adversaries, allies, and regional state actors. These extra-dyadic interactions may shape how citizens assess the security context in which rapprochement unfolds.

As a key source of extra-dyadic cue, this paper highlights third-party rivalries: rivalries in which at least one state actor lies outside the focal rivalry dyad. This focus draws on a growing literature that views international rivalries not as isolated bilateral contests, but as relationships embedded in broader networks of allies and enemies. Early scholarship on international rivalry largely emphasized endogenous processes within rivalry pairs, treating threat levels and conflict escalation as internally driven and relatively stable (Leng, 2000; Diehl & Goertz, 2001). However, a more recent literature has challenged this dyadic view by drawing on structural balance theory, which emphasizes how indirect relationships generate pressures for realignment through logics such as “the enemy of my enemy is my friend” or “the friend of my enemy is my enemy” (Heider, 1946). Dynamic models of Lee et al. (1994) show that shared allies and enemies shape the evolution and stability of rivalries, pushing interstate relations toward balanced or polarized configurations. Similarly, Maoz et al. (2007) show that third-party rivalries can reinforce balanced patterns of conflict and cooperation, as states sharing common enemies are more likely to ally while indirect enemies are more likely to fight.

Rivalry dynamics therefore unfold within a web of interdependent relationships, where changes in one dyad can reshape interactions elsewhere. For instance, pioneering work by Goldstein & Freeman (1990) shows that U.S.–China rapprochement in the early 1970s reshaped the broader U.S.–China-Soviet triangle, encouraging Soviet accommodation toward the United States while intensifying hostility between China and the Soviet Union. Beyond this triangle, U.S.–China rapprochement

facilitated diplomatic normalization between China and Japan (Vogel et al., 2002), while escalating Serbian aggression toward Bosnians prompted NATO states to adopt a more hawkish stance during the Kosovo War (Goldstein & Pevehouse, 1997).¹ Furthermore, recent scholarship has provided empirical evidence for this pattern globally. Triangular configurations involving common allies or common enemies make rivalry termination more likely, whereas mixed third-party relationships tend to prolong rivalry by generating uncertainty and conflicting incentives (Lee, 2022). Across multiple-rivalry settings, states often accommodate some rivals to manage more acute threats from others, showing how shifts in one rivalry can reflect and reshape the broader rivalry network (Akcinaroglu et al., 2014). Extra-dyadic interactions also produce reputational and signaling effects at the international level: confrontation or cooperation in one rivalry can signal preferences to potential partners and facilitate security cooperation among states with shared rivals (Mehrl et al., 2025; Yoder & Cohen, 2025).

Building on these insights, this paper treats third-party rivalries as politically meaningful cues through which publics evaluate rapprochement. Interactions among rival states beyond the focal dyad can reveal broader patterns of hostility and cooperation, shaping how citizens assess the security environment surrounding peace initiatives. Rather than viewing public attitudes toward peace as shaped only by direct exchanges between one's own state and its adversary, this approach posits that citizens evaluate adversaries and conciliatory policies within an international environment structured by networked rivalries. The following section specifies the microfoundations of this argument.

¹Still, focused studies of U.S. relations in the Middle East suggest that triangular responses, while often present, are not sufficient on their own to predict long-term changes in conflict and cooperation (Goldstein et al., 2001).

Theory and Hypotheses

This paper argues that intensified hostility in third-party rivalries can reinforce public resistance to peace by sharpening the *enemy image* through which citizens interpret a focal rival state. Individuals do not process all available information when forming foreign policy attitudes; instead, they often rely on national images as heuristic cues “to simplify a complex international environment and to guide perceptions of, and responses toward, particular countries” (Hurwitz & Peffley, 1990, 6). In contexts of international rivalry, foreign policy attitudes are strongly shaped by concerns about national security and strategic interests (Cottam, 1977; Peffley & Hurwitz, 1992). Citizens are therefore likely to organize relevant images around a simplified ally-enemy distinction (Boulding, 1956; Herrmann, 1985; Kaplowitz, 1990; Schafer, 1997). Two dimensions are especially important for this distinction: (1) the extent to which a state is viewed as posing a threat or providing security benefits and (2) the degree to which its political or ideological goals are seen as aligning with those of the individual’s own nation (Herrmann & Fischerkeller, 1995; Alexander et al., 2005). States perceived as threatening or as pursuing incompatible goals are likely to be assigned an enemy image, whereas states seen as providing security benefits or sharing compatible national goals are likely to be viewed as allies. Citizens who view another state as hostile or threatening are more likely to support hawkish and confrontational policies (Huddy et al., 2005; Gadarian, 2010). Accordingly, stronger enemy images of a rival state should be associated with greater public opposition to reconciliation.

Importantly, the rival’s enemy image is not formed or evaluated solely within the rivalry dyad. Citizens may also interpret foreign states through social boundaries that place them within broader networks of conflict, cooperation, and shared identity. In rivalry contexts, these boundaries organize foreign states into collective categories of allies and enemies through two related mechanisms. First, multi-party wars and conflicts that gave rise to the focal rivalry reveal broader patterns of security alignment. When wars with a foreign adversary become internationalized, citizens may

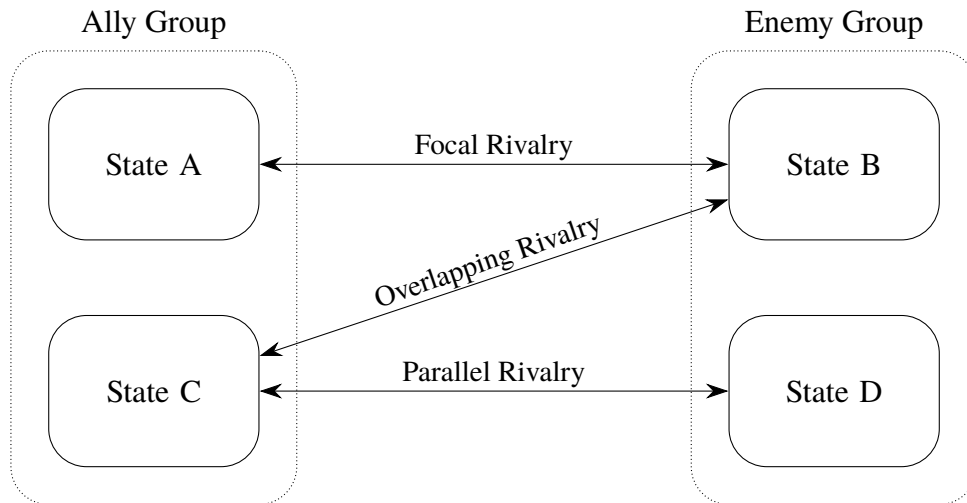
minimize distinctions among states associated with their own side while intensifying negative perceptions of states placed in the opposing camp (Migdal et al., 2001; Risse-Kappen, 2016). In this case, states fighting alongside one's own country or its partners are more likely to be interpreted as security opportunities, whereas states aligned with rival powers are more likely to be perceived as threats. Second, even in the absence of direct conflict, shared political, ideological, or institutional characteristics can signal goal (in)compatibility. The IR scholarship has suggested that countries associated with similar norms and culture (Mercer, 1995), international organizations (Johnston, 2008), or regime types (Gartzke & Weisiger, 2013; Chu, 2021) can be viewed as members of a shared community, while those associated with opposing characteristics can be placed in an out-group. Likewise, states associated with the focal rival through shared ideological, institutional, or political traits may be perceived as part of the same opposing camp, whereas states defined by contrasting traits can be viewed as allies or potential partners.

This social-categorization logic explains how third-party rivalries can affect public attitudes toward a focal adversary. If the enemy image of a focal rival reflects its perceived membership in a broader out-group, then conflict involving other members of two opposing blocs can shape how the focal rival is perceived, even without direct escalation in the focal dyad. Social Identity Theory holds that individuals derive part of their identity from the groups to which they belong, so inter-group interactions influence how they evaluate both their own group and relevant out-groups (Tajfel, 1981; Turner & Oakes, 1986). Also, individuals observing rising tensions between some members of an in-group and an out-group can intensify hostility towards the entire out-group members, while simultaneously strengthening their emotional attachment to people in their in-group (Hogg, 1992; Gibler et al., 2012). In international politics, social perceptions of states operate as filters through which citizens categorize foreign states as friends or enemies (Mercer, 1995; Gartzke & Weisiger, 2013). Rising tensions between perceived allies and enemies can make these boundaries more salient, leading citizens to interpret a third-party dispute as part of a broader confrontation between opposing camps. As a result, intensified rivalries involving allied and adversarial states can spill

over onto the focal rival by reaffirming the foreign adversary’s membership in the enemy group, sharpening its enemy image, and increasing resistance to peace with that country.

These dynamics are visible across a range of regional security environments. From the perspective of Israeli citizens, Iran may be evaluated not only through direct Israel-Iran hostility, but also through the broader U.S.-Iran rivalry. Because the United States is Israel’s principal security partner, confrontation between Washington and Tehran can reaffirm Iran’s position in the enemy camp, sharpen its adversarial image, and make conciliation appear less acceptable. Likewise, as the Russia-Ukraine war intensified, Polish and other Eastern European publics may have viewed Belarus more negatively in recent years, not only because of bilateral concerns, but also because Belarus’s alignment with Russia placed it more clearly within the enemy camp. A similar logic may operate in South Asia, where Indian citizens’ perceptions of Pakistan can be shaped not only by the India-Pakistan rivalry, but also by Pakistan’s relationship with China and the broader strategic competition involving the United States in the region.

Figure 1: Networked Rivalries across Perceived Ally and Enemy Groups



To zoom in this mechanism more closely, [Figure 1](#) maps the relevant actors and third-party rivalry ties within this perceived ally-enemy structure. In the figure, *State A* is the home state of individual *i*, and *State B* is the focal rival. From the public’s perspective, however, the international

environment also includes other states that are socially categorized as allies or enemies. *State C*, for example, is perceived as an ally because it provides security benefits to *State A* or shares compatible national goals. By contrast, *State D* is perceived as an enemy because it is strategically aligned with *State B* or shares similar institutional, ideological, or cultural characteristics. In this setting, the enemy image of the focal rival, *State B*, can be reinforced not only by conflict within the focal rivalry between *State A* and *State B*, but also by rivalries involving other members of the perceived ally and enemy camps. Here, I distinguish between two forms of such third-party rivalry when *State A* is not directly involved. The key distinction is whether the focal rival, *State B*, is itself a participant in the third-party rivalry. The first form is an *overlapping rivalry*, which refers to a third-party rivalry that directly involves the focal rival: for example, *State B* may be engaged in rivalry with an ally of *State A*, such as *State C*. The second form is a *parallel rivalry*, which refers to a third-party rivalry that crosses the same perceived ally-enemy boundary but does not directly involve the focal rival: for instance, *State C* may be engaged in rivalry with another perceived enemy, *State D*, while *State B* remains outside that specific rivalry.

An overlapping rivalry can make the enemy image of a focal rival more salient by heightening perceptions of intergroup confrontation. Related ideas appear in existing research under different terms, including indirect friendship and enmity (Maoz et al., 2007), complex rivalries (Valeriano & Powers, 2016), and Rivalry–Rivalry–Ally triangular configurations (Lee, 2022). Drawing on the theoretical intuition of structural balance theory (Heider, 1946, 1982), these perspectives suggest that conflict between “my enemy” and “my friend” can intensify the source state’s hostility toward the enemy. My argument builds on this intuition but emphasizes a distinct micro-level mechanism: citizens may interpret conflict between a focal rival and an allied state not simply as a bilateral dispute, but as evidence of broader confrontation across ally-enemy boundaries. This perception can generate spillover through image polarization. When actors aligned with opposing camps engage in conflict, citizens may perceive greater distance between allies and enemies, reinforcing positive images of allied states and negative images of adversarial states. For instance, in Figure 1, inten-

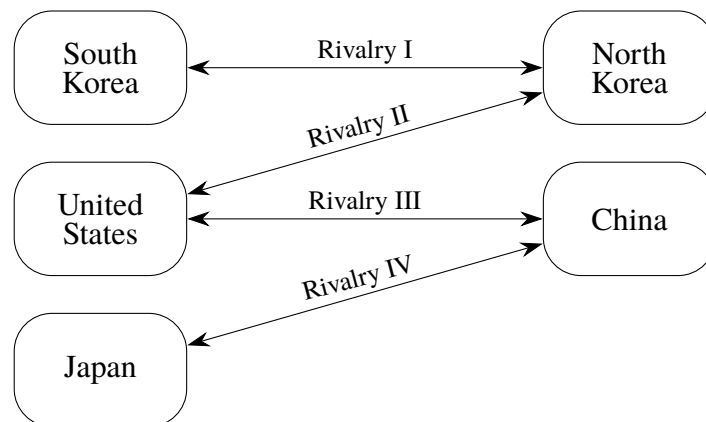
sified rivalry between *State B* and *State C* should not only reinforce pre-existing images of those two states, but also spill over to other states associated with the same enemy camp, such as *State D*. Accordingly, I expect an intensified rivalry between a focal rival and an allied state (*overlapping rivalry*) to make the focal rival's enemy image more salient (*H1A*) and increase domestic opposition to peace with that adversary (*H1B*). I also expect this rivalry conflict to produce broader image polarization, making allied states appear more favorable and enemy-aligned states appear more threatening, even when they are not directly involved in the conflict.

A similar logic applies to the effect of a parallel rivalry on public attitudes toward the focal rival. This type of third rivalry has received less attention by the existing rivalry literature as it is not directly connected to the focal rivalry dyad. As shown in [Figure 1](#), a parallel rivalry refers to a hostile relationship between *State C* and *State D*, which does not directly involve the focal rival, *State B*. From a purely dyadic perspective, this rivalry may appear irrelevant to how citizens evaluate *State B*. However, from a social-categorization perspective, the connection is indirect but meaningful: *State C* is perceived as part of the in-group, while *State D* is perceived as part of the out-group. Conflict between them can therefore be interpreted not simply as a separate bilateral dispute, but as another instance of confrontation between ally and enemy groups. By making the broader ally-enemy boundary more salient, a parallel rivalry can polarize existing national images beyond the states directly involved in the conflict. In this process, the focal rival, *State B*, may also be viewed more negatively because it is associated with the same enemy camp as *State D*. Based on this logic, I expect higher levels of perceived rivalry between an allied state and another perceived enemy (*parallel rivalry*) to reinforce the focal rival's enemy image (*H2A*) and increase domestic opposition to peace with that rival (*H2B*).

Empirical Studies of Networked Rivalries in East Asia

To test my theoretical claims, I draw on evidence from two empirical studies of networked rivalries involving East Asian states. Existing research has identified East Asia as an important setting for examining the causes and consequences of interdependence among international rivalries (Vogel et al., 2002; Valeriano & Powers, 2016; Lee, 2022). Along with this literature, the empirical analyses of this paper leverage the region's dense network of interstate relationships. As illustrated in Figure 2, this paper focuses on the interconnections among four rivalries: the inter-Korean rivalry (*Rivalry I*), the U.S.-DPRK rivalry (*Rivalry II*), the U.S.-China rivalry (*Rivalry III*), and the Japan-China rivalry (*Rivalry IV*). The following empirical studies assess whether and to what extent heightened tensions within one rivalry spill over into another by analyzing how public opinion toward a foreign adversary is shaped by a third-party rivalry in the region. Table 1 summarizes their key features.

Figure 2: Networked Rivalries in East Asia



In Study 1, I use text analysis on social media in South Korea and Japan to examine whether and how conflict escalation in a third-party rivalry is associated with changes in public attitudes toward foreign adversaries. This approach builds on a growing body of research that uses online media platforms to measure foreign policy attitudes in East Asia (Sung & Park, 2022; Zhang & Wang, 2024; Zhang & Chen, 2026), where public opinion toward international actors and foreign policy is actively expressed and circulated through digital communication. The dependent variables

Table 1: Summary of Two Empirical Studies on Networked Rivalries

Study	Empirical Method	Public Opinion (Dependent Variable)	Third-Party Rivalry (Independent Variable)	Hypothesis Test
Study I	Social Media Text Analysis	[<i>Rivalry I</i>] South Korean Opinion Toward North Korea	[<i>Rivalry II</i>] U.S.-DPRK Rivalry	Overlapping Rivalry (<i>H1A</i> & <i>H1B</i>)
		[<i>Rivalry IV</i>] Japanese Opinion Toward China		Parallel Rivalry (<i>H2A</i> & <i>H2B</i>)
Study II	Survey Experiment	[<i>Rivalry III</i>] American Opinion Toward China	[<i>Rivalry IV</i>] Japan-China Rivalry	Overlapping Rivalry (<i>H1A</i> & <i>H1B</i>)
			[<i>Rivalry I</i>] Inter-Korean Rivalry	Parallel Rivalry (<i>H2A</i> & <i>H2B</i>)

are public opinion in two focal rivalries: South Korean opinion toward North Korea (*Rivalry I*) and Japanese opinion toward China (*Rivalry IV*). The independent variable is conflict in the U.S.-DPRK rivalry (*Rivalry II*), which serves as the third-party rivalry in both cases. For South Korean opinion toward North Korea (*Rivalry I*), this is an overlapping rivalry because South Korea and the United States share North Korea as a common adversary, corresponding to *H1A* and *H1B*. For Japanese opinion toward China (*Rivalry IV*), it is a parallel rivalry because the U.S.-DPRK rivalry does not directly involve China but may still shape perceptions through the broader regional security environment, corresponding to *H2A* and *H2B*.

This methodological approach provides a useful test of the hypotheses in a real-world setting with high ecological validity as it examines rivalry dynamics that are central to domestic political debates in East Asia. However, the social media text analysis also has important limitations. From a causal inference perspective, observational data make it difficult to isolate the effect of third-party rivalry dynamics because international tensions are not randomly assigned and may coincide with other factors—such as contemporaneous events, elite rhetoric, or media coverage—that also shape public opinion toward the focal adversary (Kertzer & Tingley, 2018). Additionally, observational social media data are limited in their ability to test the paper’s theoretical mechanism. According to

the theory, conflict in one rivalry can reshape public images of multiple foreign actors simultaneously, but social media data make it difficult to measure these perceptions of allies and adversaries within the broader regional network. A further limitation of social media data is that they are less suitable for measuring public opinion toward conciliatory policy because explicit discussions of rapprochement are relatively rare in ordinary online discourse. Finally, social media users are not representative of the broader public, and online discourse may overrepresent politically engaged, ideologically extreme, or highly vocal users.

For these reasons, Study II complements the social media analysis with a survey experiment in the United States, testing the theoretical argument in a more controlled setting. The survey format of this study allows me to ask respondents directly about their attitudes toward multiple states and reconciliation toward the focal rival. Additionally, the experimental design randomly varies exposure to different third-party rivalry cues while holding other contextual information constant. In this study, the dependent variable is American opinion toward China in the U.S.-China rivalry (*Rivalry III*), measured through respondents' perceived enemy image of China as well as their perceptions of other relevant regional actors, including Japan, South Korea, and North Korea. The experimental treatments vary the level of conflict in the third-party rivalry to which respondents are exposed using relevant news video clips. One set of treatments presents different types of information about the Japan-China rivalry (*Rivalry IV*), which tests the overlapping-rivalry hypothesis because Japan is a U.S. ally and China is the focal U.S. adversary, corresponding to [H1A](#) and [H1B](#). Another set of treatments presents varying information about the inter-Korean rivalry (*Rivalry I*), which tests the parallel-rivalry hypothesis because it involves a U.S. ally, South Korea, and another regional adversary, North Korea, but not the focal rival, China, corresponding to [H2A](#) and [H2B](#).

Study I: Text Analysis on Social Media in South Korea and Japan

Research Design

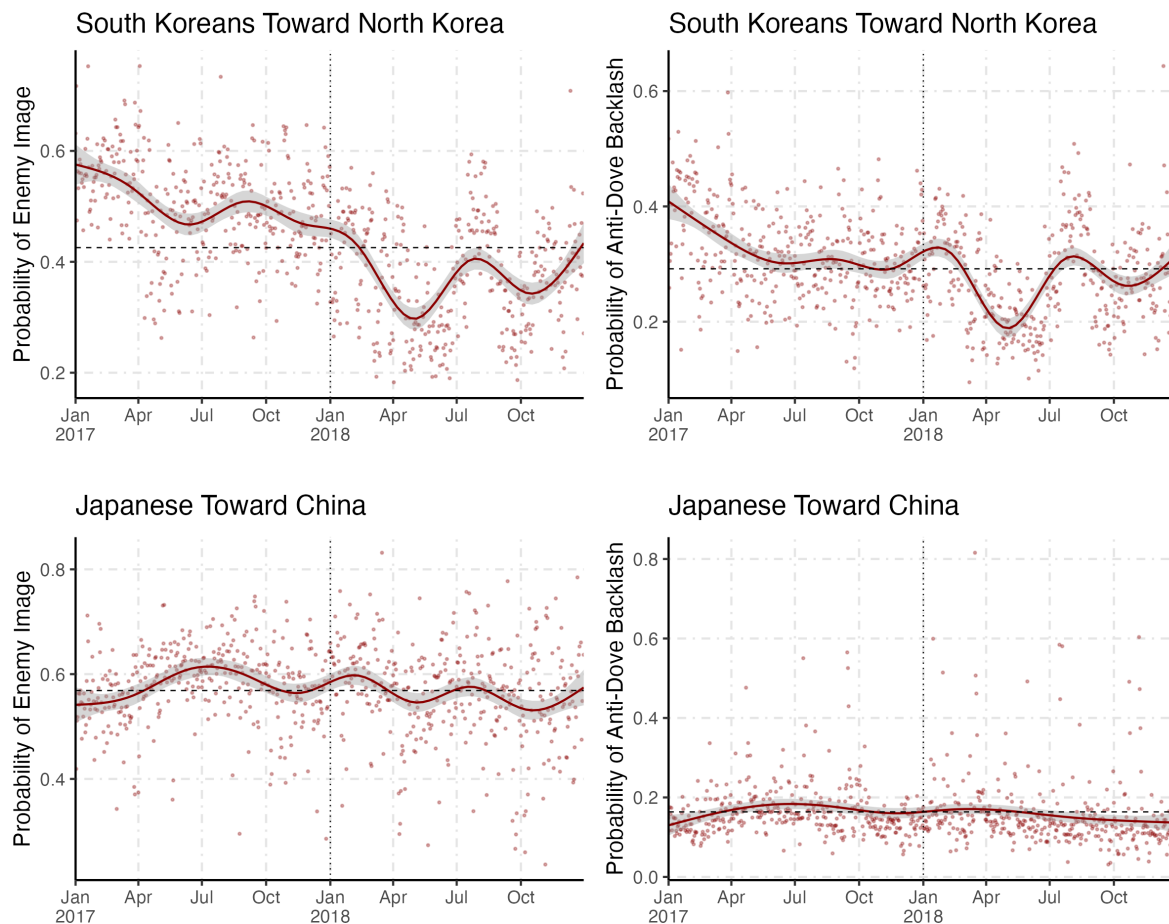
Study I examines how the U.S.–DPRK rivalry shaped public perceptions in South Korea and Japan between 2017 and 2018, particularly toward their respective rival states, North Korea and China. This period provides a useful setting for testing the paper’s theoretical mechanism because the U.S.–DPRK relationship underwent dramatic shifts, moving from acute military tension in 2017 to unprecedented diplomatic engagement in 2018. In 2017, U.S.–North Korea tensions escalated sharply as North Korea conducted long-range missile launches and its sixth nuclear test, while the Trump administration responded with threats of “fire and fury” ([Reuters, 2017](#)) and a “maximum pressure” strategy combining sanctions and military deterrence ([BBC News, 2017](#)). In 2018, however, the relationship changed markedly. North Korea’s participation in the Winter Olympics in South Korea signaled a temporary thaw that led to diplomatic exchanges, including U.S. Secretary of State Mike Pompeo’s visits to Pyongyang, and culminated in the Singapore summit, where Kim Jong-un and Donald Trump issued a joint statement pledging to work toward the complete denuclearization of the Korean Peninsula.

To measure public attitudes toward rival states, this study uses Twitter, now known as X, as the primary source of social media data in both South Korea and Japan. Although users on online platforms are not representative of the broader population, Twitter was one of the most widely used social media platforms in both countries during the study period.² At the end of April 2023, when Twitter still provided free data access for academic research, I collected tweets that could capture public sentiment in South Korea and Japan toward their respective foreign adversaries, North Korea and China. For the Korean case, the search focused on Korean-language posts from 2017 and 2018

²In South Korea, 13.7% of social media users reportedly used Twitter as their primary platform in 2017 and 2018 ([KISDI, 2022, 12](#)). In Japan, approximately 38% of the total population were estimated to use Twitter during the same period on average ([MIC of Japan, 2022, 69](#)).

that referenced terms such as “North Korea (북한 or 대북)” or “Kim Jong-un (김정은).” This process yielded 729,867 tweets and retweets posted by 695,821 unique users. For the Japanese case, I collected 366,543 tweets from 366,148 unique users that mentioned “China (中国, 支那, or 對中),” “Xi Jinping (習近平),” or “Chinese Communist Party (共黨).”

Figure 3: Enemy Image and Anti-Dovish Sentiment in South Korea and Japan (2017-18)



Note: The smooth lines report Generalized Additive Model (GAM) estimates with 95% confidence intervals. The dashed horizontal line in each panel represents the two-year average for the corresponding measure.

Next, this study uses supervised machine-learning models to construct the dependent variables measuring public attitudes toward rival states. To train the model, 10,000 Korean tweets and 5,000 Japanese tweets were randomly sampled and manually annotated by regional experts who are na-

tive speakers of the respective languages.³ Drawing on the conceptualization of enemy images as rooted in perceived threats and goal incompatibility (Herrmann et al., 1997; Alexander et al., 1999), tweets were coded as 1 if they described the adversary as a security threat or expressed conflicting national goals or interests. These annotations were then used to create a binary variable, labeled “enemy image,” coded as 1 when at least one of these two dimensions was present. A second dependent variable, labeled “anti-dove backlash,” captures criticism of domestic political actors for adopting conciliatory stances toward the foreign adversary. Because direct expressions of support for or opposition to conciliatory policy are relatively rare in social media discourse, this measure provides an indirect indicator of public resistance to conciliation. Tweets expressing such criticism were coded as 1, otherwise 0. Using the annotated data, Support Vector Classification (SVC) and Random Forest classifiers were trained separately for each country-language corpus and dependent variable, then applied to the full corpus to estimate the predicted probability that each tweet expressed an enemy image or anti-dove backlash.⁴

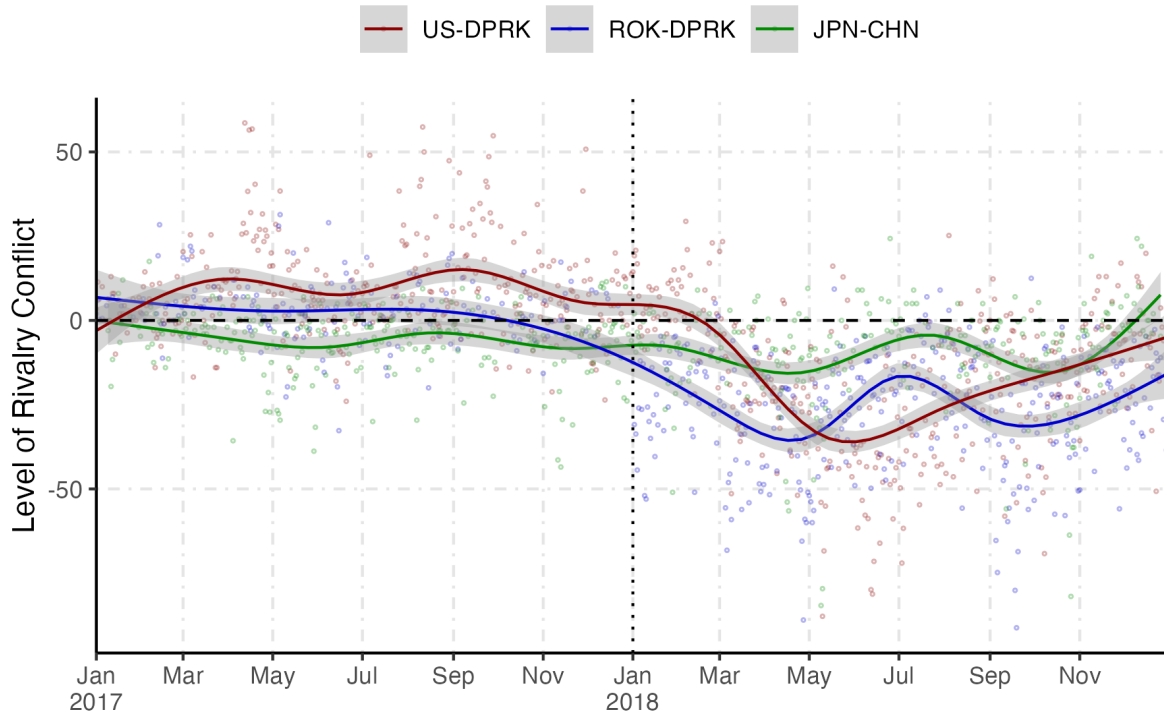
Figure 3 presents the predicted probabilities of enemy image and anti-dove backlash in South Korea and Japan between 2017 and 2018. Each dot indicates the daily average level of enemy image or anti-dove backlash. The graphs show that enemy images are more prevalent than anti-dove backlash in both cases, but the average probability of enemy image is higher among Japanese tweets about China than among South Korean tweets about North Korea. By contrast, anti-dove backlash is more common in South Korean discourse on North Korea than in Japanese discourse on China, where it remains relatively low throughout the period. In terms of temporal patterns, South Korean tweets show a more pronounced decline in both enemy image and anti-dove backlash during 2018, whereas Japanese tweets exhibit a more modest downward trend, especially in enemy images of China.

To measure the level of rivalry conflict between the United States and North Korea, this study

³For further details on the annotation samples, see Appendix 1.1.

⁴Refer to Appendices 1.2 and 1.3. for additional information on model performance and the predicted values of the dependent variables.

Figure 4: Levels of Rivalry Conflicts in East Asia (2017-18)



Note: The smooth lines report GAM estimates with 95% confidence intervals.

uses the Integrated Conflict Early Warning System (ICEWS) as the source of the independent variable. Initially developed to assist U.S. policy analysts in forecasting international conflicts ([Boschee et al., 2018](#)), ICEWS has a valuable source of empirical data for recent research on interstate conflicts and cooperation ([Kinne & Maoz, 2023](#); [Myrick & Wang, 2023](#); [Han, 2025](#)). This dataset is particularly well suited for this study because it captures the intensity of hostile actions between state actors on a scale from -10 to +10, enabling systematic measurement of rivalry interactions in 2017 and 2018, while its reliance on news media sources suggests that these foreign policy behaviors were likely visible to citizens in South Korea and Japan.

[Figure 4](#) displays the level of rivalry conflict across three East Asian rivalries between 2017 and 2018 using ICEWS event data. Each colored dot indicates the daily net level of conflict between a pair of states, calculated by subtracting the total intensity of hostile actions from the total intensity of cooperative actions observed on that day. The figure illustrates that the U.S.-DPRK rivalry ex-

perienced the most dramatic shift: conflict remained relatively high throughout much of 2017 but declined sharply in early 2018. The ROK-DPRK rivalry follows a broadly similar but less volatile pattern, moving from relatively neutral levels in 2017 toward lower levels of conflict in 2018 as inter-Korean diplomacy intensified. By contrast, the Japan-China rivalry remains comparatively stable and less sharply affected by the 2017–2018 diplomatic turn, although it also shows some decline in conflict during 2018 before rising again toward the end of the year.

$$Y_{it} = \alpha + \beta_1 \text{US-DPRK Conflict}_{t-1} + \beta_2 \text{Focal Rivalry Conflict}_{t-1} + \gamma_1 \text{Text Length}_{it} + \gamma_2 \text{Unique Text}_{it} + \gamma_3 \text{Retweet}_{it} + \epsilon_{it}. \quad (1)$$

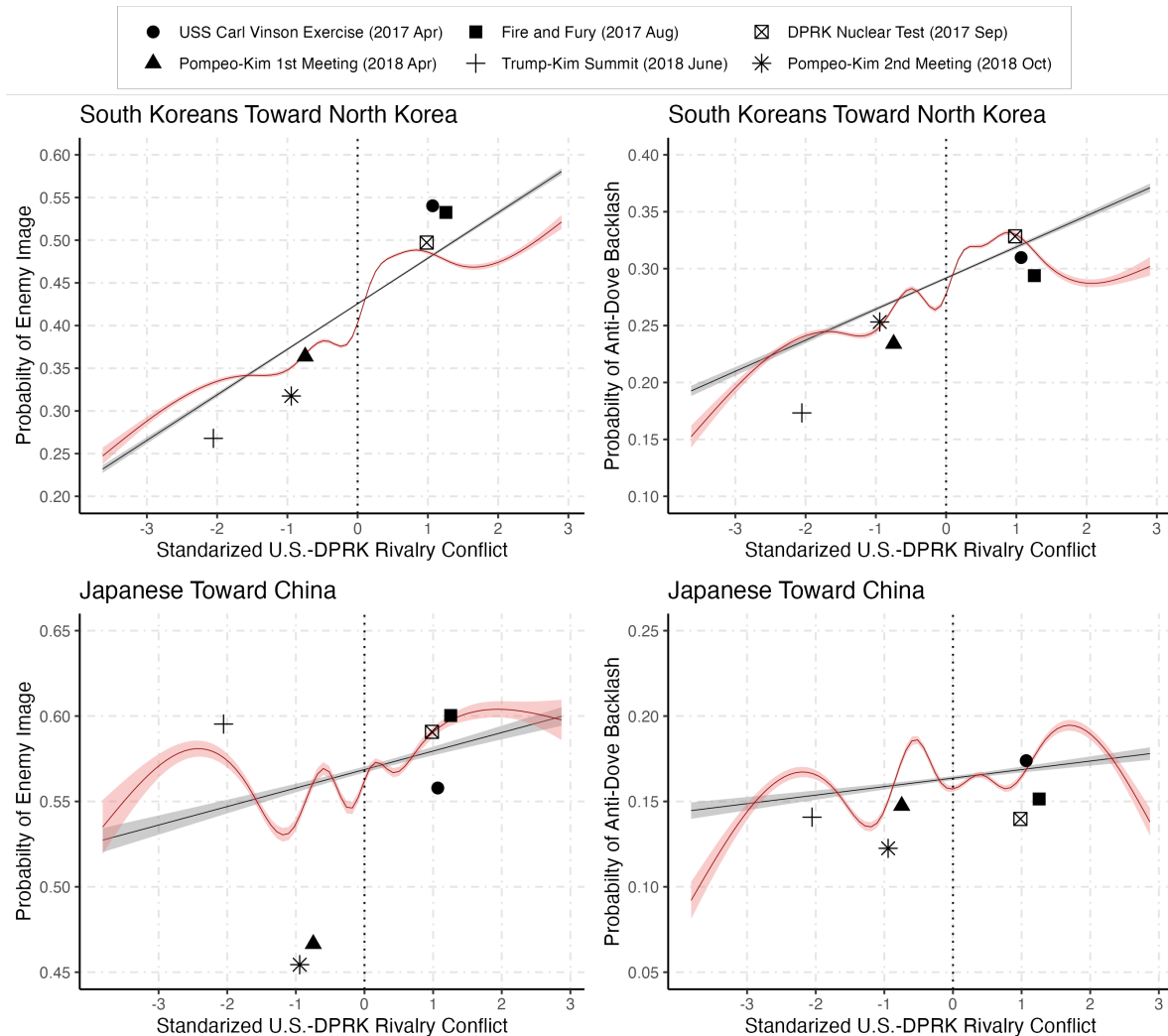
[Equation 1](#) presents the OLS regression model specification for empirical analyses. Here, Y_{it} denotes the predicted probability that tweet i posted on day t expresses either an enemy image or anti-dove backlash toward the focal rival. The main independent variable is $\text{US-DPRK Conflict}_{t-1}$, which captures the level of conflict between the United States and North Korea on day $t - 1$. The model also includes $\text{Focal Rivalry Conflict}_{t-1}$, which refers to ROK-DPRK conflict in the South Korean analysis and JPN-PRC conflict in the Japanese analysis. This allows me to assess whether U.S.-DPRK conflict remains associated with public attitudes toward the focal rival even after accounting for contemporaneous conflict within the direct rivalry dyad. The model also includes several tweet-level control variables. I control for tweet length because longer tweets may contain more substantive political content and therefore may be more likely to be classified as expressing enemy images or anti-dove backlash. The model also includes an indicator for whether the tweet text is unique, since repeated texts may reflect coordinated messaging, automated activity, or viral reposting. Finally, the model includes an indicator for whether the post is a retweet, since retweets may capture diffusion or amplification rather than independent expression of hostility.

Results

The first part of the analysis examines evidence from South Korea using bivariate OLS models, which speak to the first set of hypotheses regarding the effects of interstate behavior between an ally and a rival state in an overlapping rivalry. Overall, the findings are consistent with both [H1A](#) and [H1B](#), indicating that heightened hostility between the United States and North Korea increases South Korean public resistance to reconciliation with North Korea. As shown in the top-left panel of [Figure 5](#), U.S.–DPRK conflict is positively associated with the likelihood that South Korean tweets portray North Korea as an enemy. The upward-sloping OLS line and narrow confidence interval indicate a statistically significant positive relationship: a one-standard-deviation increase in U.S.–DPRK conflict is associated with a 5.33 percentage point increase ($p < 0.001$) in the probability that South Korean tweets characterize North Korea as an enemy. The top-right panel shows a similar pattern for anti-dove backlash: as U.S.–DPRK conflict increases, South Korean tweets become more likely to criticize the domestic political actors who are conciliatory toward North Korea. Specifically, a one-standard-deviation increase in U.S.–DPRK conflict corresponds to a 2.73 percentage point increase in such domestic backlash ($p < 0.001$).

Next, the analysis turns to Japan, where I use bivariate OLS models to evaluate empirical support for [H2A](#) and [H2B](#). Overall, the findings from Japanese Twitter data are consistent with the expectation that conflict between an ally and a rival’s ally in a parallel rivalry can heighten domestic opposition to rapprochement. The bottom-left panel of [Figure 5](#) shows that U.S.–DPRK conflict is positively associated with the likelihood that Japanese tweets portray China as an enemy. Although this pattern mirrors the South Korean case, the effect is more modest: a one-standard-deviation increase in U.S.–DPRK conflict corresponds to a 1.08 percentage point increase in negative portrayals of China ($p < 0.001$). The bottom-right panel shows a similar but weaker pattern for anti-dove backlash: a one-standard-deviation increase in U.S.–DPRK conflict is associated with a 0.49 percentage point increase in anti-dove backlash ($p < 0.001$).

Figure 5: Effects of U.S.-DPRK Rivalry on Enemy Image and Anti-Dove Backlash



Note: The solid lines in this graph represent the predicted line from the OLS model, whereas the dashed curved lines correspond to the GAM smoothed line. The ribbons around the regression lines indicate the 95% confidence interval. The data points associated with the listed events represent the average probability within a week before and after the occurrence of each respective event.

As these graphics illustrates, this pattern is also evident around major hostile and cooperative events. In South Korea, tweets portrayed North Korea much more negatively during periods of U.S.-DPRK hostility than during periods of rapprochement: the average probability of enemy images was approximately 54.03 percent around the USS Carl Vinson’s approach to the Korean Peninsula, 53.25 percent following President Trump’s “fire and fury” statement, and 49.72 percent

around North Korea's sixth nuclear test, compared to 36.38 percent around Pompeo's first visit to Pyongyang, 26.79 percent around the Trump–Kim summit in Singapore, and 31.75 percent around Pompeo's second visit to Pyongyang. A similar pattern appears in Japan, where the probability that tweets portrayed China as an enemy was about 55–60 percent during hostile U.S.–DPRK episodes, compared to an average of 50.54 percent across the three corresponding periods of cooperation. Anti-dove backlash follows a similar pattern in South Korea, where criticism of conciliatory domestic actors reached about 29–33 percent during hostile episodes but declined to about 17–25 percent during cooperative episodes. In Japan, this pattern is weaker but generally consistent: criticism of conciliatory domestic actors was about 14–17 percent during hostile episodes, compared to about 12–15 percent during cooperative episodes.

The robustness checks indicate that the main findings are generally stable across alternative specifications, as shown in Appendix 1.4. First, the results remain consistent in multivariate OLS models that account for conflict within the focal rivalry dyads and include tweet-level controls, although the estimated effects are smaller than in the bivariate analysis. U.S.–DPRK conflict continues to be positively associated with enemy images and anti-dove backlash in both South Korea and Japan, suggesting that ally-rival conflict shapes public attitudes toward the focal rival beyond the effects of direct rivalry conflict. Second, I re-estimate the models using alternative temporal specifications, including a 7-day average of the conflict variables, and find consistent results. Finally, I re-estimate the models with standard errors clustered by date, since the conflict variables vary at the daily level while the outcomes are observed at the tweet level. The results remain substantively unchanged.

Study II: Survey Experiment in the United States

Research Design

In the second study, I conduct a survey experiment to examine how Americans perceive China and evaluate the prospect of bilateral cooperation. China's rise has intensified geopolitical tensions with the United States (Kertzer et al., 2024), contributing to public hostility and negative stereotypes that may create domestic barriers to reconciliation (Xu, 2025). Given the salience of this rivalry and its implications for global stability, a growing body of research has examined public opinion on foreign policy amid rising U.S.-China tensions (Mattes & Weeks, 2019; Myrick, 2021; Kertzer et al., 2024; Han et al., 2026). Yet the U.S.-China rivalry does not unfold in isolation. The United States has long been embedded in a broader regional security environment in East Asia, shaped by the Korean War, the Cold War, and alliance commitments. In this context, Americans tend to view Japan and South Korea as allies, while perceiving China as a principal adversary and North Korea as China's strategic partner (Friedhoff, 2020; Kafura, 2022).⁵ Building on this broader context, the experiment examines whether information about third-party rivalries in East Asia shapes Americans' perceptions of China and their support for rapprochement with China.

In August 2023, I fielded a pre-registered survey experiment with a nationally representative sample of 1,412 American adults through Lucid Theorem.⁶ The survey proceeded in several stages. First, respondents answered a series of demographic questions, including gender, age, religion, household income, education, partisan identity, and political ideology. Participants were then randomly assigned to either a control condition or one of four treatment conditions. As Table 2 shows,

⁵According to the October 2022 survey by the Chicago Council on Global Affairs (Kafura, 2022), American ratings of South Korea and Japan on a 0–100 feeling thermometer averaged 72 and 62, respectively, compared to 32 for China and 20 for North Korea. Over the past decade, American perceptions of these two groups of countries have become increasingly divergent (Friedhoff, 2020).

⁶The experimental design was approved by the author's home institution and pre-registered with the Open Science Framework (OSF) prior to data collection. The main analysis focuses on 1,241 respondents who successfully passed the survey's pre-treatment attention check. Additional details are provided with the full survey instrument in Appendix 2.3.

the treatment conditions varied along two dimensions: whether the observed interaction involved rivalry conflict or rivalry cooperation, and whether the interaction occurred within an overlapping rivalry between China and Japan or a parallel rivalry between North and South Korea. The rivalry-cooperation treatments are included to clarify the mechanism underlying the effects of third-party rivalry conflict. If the conflict treatments were compared only to the control condition, it would be unclear whether any observed effects reflected exposure to the third-party rivalry itself, the conflictual nature of the interaction, or both. The cooperation treatments therefore provide comparison groups that hold the third-party rivalry constant while varying whether the observed interaction is conflictual or cooperative.

Table 2: Treatment Groups and Corresponding Video Clips on Third-Party Rivalries

	Rivalry Conflict	Rivalry Cooperation
Overlapping Rivalry (Japan-China)	Treatment 1 (N = 247): “Diaoyu-Senkaku islands spat deepens as Japan warns China over coastguard ships in East China Sea” (2020/10/14)	Treatment 2 (N = 280): “Japan’s foreign minister to visit China after leaders Fumio Kishida and Xi Jinping meet at APEC” (2022/11/18)
Parallel Rivalry (South-North Korea)	Treatment 3 (N = 249): “South Korea opens fire as North Korea drones cross the border” (2022/12/27)	Treatment 4 (N = 274): “North and South Korea restore communication and military hotline after 2 months of silence” (2021/10/05)

Subjects in these treatment groups were exposed to a video clip that showcases an international affair that highlights relationships relevant to each category. The selected events were chosen because they provide clear and recent examples of conflict and cooperation within each rivalry, while avoiding cases that were so widely known that respondents were likely to have strong pre-existing attitudes toward the specific events. The first two treatments focus on an *overlapping rivalry* between Japan and China, with Treatment 1 depicting a hostile maritime dispute over the Senkaku/Diaoyu Islands in 2020, and Treatment 2 highlighting their diplomatic engagement following high-level bilateral talks at APEC in 2022. The third and fourth treatments shift focus to a *parallel rivalry*

between South and North Korea. Treatment 3 presents a hostile incident involving North Korean drones violating South Korean airspace in 2022, prompting a military response, while Treatment 4 features a cooperative moment in which the two countries reestablish communication through a restored military hotline in 2021. The participants allocated to the control group did not view any video clip ($N = 191$).

Regarding the treatment materials, I used real media content because it is believed to enhance participants' engagement and comprehension, resulting in more accurate and meaningful responses that closely mirror real-life reactions. In this regard, the video clips were selected from news coverage published by the South China Morning Post (SCMP) on its publicly available YouTube channel. The decision to use material from the SCMP, rather than from American media outlets, was made for two reasons. First, SCMP provided recent news coverage corresponding to each of the four treatment categories, allowing me to construct treatment materials from a consistent media source across conditions. Second, relying on a non-American source reduced the possibility that respondents' pre-existing attitudes toward domestic media outlets would shape their responses to the treatment. Relevantly, the treatment videos excluded reporter information and source labels, exposing respondents only to the relevant textual and visual content. Source information was withheld during the treatment stage and disclosed only in the debriefing. For details on each video clip, see Appendix 2.2.

After the treatment stage, the survey measured two sets of dependent variables. First, respondents evaluated the national images of China, North Korea, Japan, and South Korea. They rated each country on 0–10 scales measuring whether it was perceived as an enemy or ally of the United States, with country names presented in random order. Additionally, following prior work on ally and enemy images ([Herrmann et al., 1997](#); [Alexander et al., 2005](#)), the survey included supplementary items measuring perceived threat and goal compatibility. Second, the survey measured support for cooperative policy toward China. Respondents indicated their agreement with three items capturing support for easing tensions, enhancing partnership, and endorsing a leader who promotes

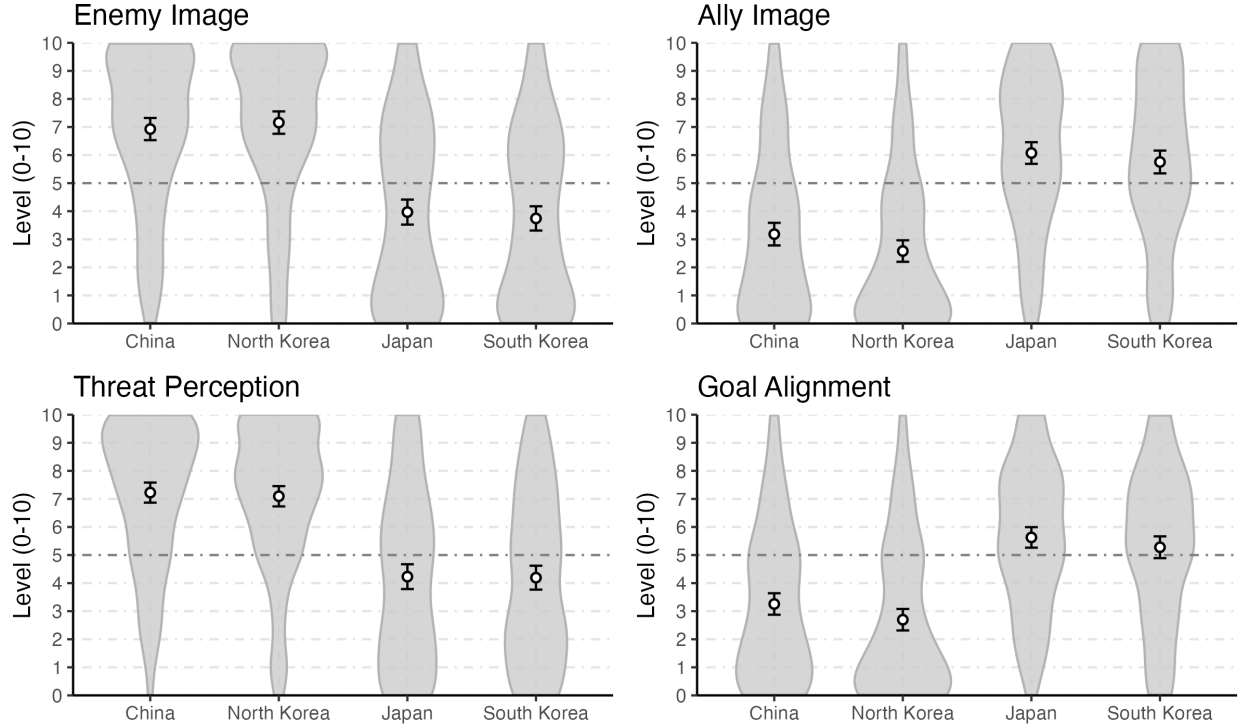
cooperation with China, using a seven-point scale ranging from “strongly disagree” to “strongly agree.”

Results

The initial analysis of the survey experiment examines how American respondents in the control group perceive four key countries—China, North Korea, Japan, and South Korea—across several dimensions of international image. As shown in [Figure 6](#), the findings align with previous survey results, revealing a clear distinction between U.S. allies and adversaries in East Asia. China and North Korea are evaluated more negatively: their average enemy-image scores are 6.93 and 7.16, respectively, and their average threat-perception scores are similarly high at 7.23 and 7.09. By contrast, Japan and South Korea receive lower enemy-image scores, averaging 3.97 and 3.74, and lower threat-perception scores, averaging 4.23 and 4.19. The reverse pattern appears for positive images. Japan and South Korea receive higher ally-image scores, averaging 6.07 and 5.75, and higher goal-alignment scores, averaging 5.63 and 5.28, whereas China and North Korea receive lower ally-image scores of 3.18 and 2.58 and lower goal-alignment scores of 3.26 and 2.70. Overall, these patterns support the core premise of Study II’s experimental design: American respondents clearly differentiate between allied and rival states when forming opinions about international relations in East Asia.

Having established these baseline perceptions, the analysis turns to the study’s main hypothesis tests by first examining the effects of an overlapping rivalry involving an ally and a rival state, represented by Japan and China in the experiment. According to [H1A](#), conflict within this overlapping rivalry should worsen Americans’ perceptions of China. The results provide support for this expectation. As shown in [Figure 7](#), respondents exposed to conflict between China and Japan over the Senkaku/Diaoyu Islands evaluated China more negatively than respondents in the control condition. In the models without demographic controls, the Japan-China conflict treatment increases

Figure 6: American Perceptions of East Asian Countries in the Control Group

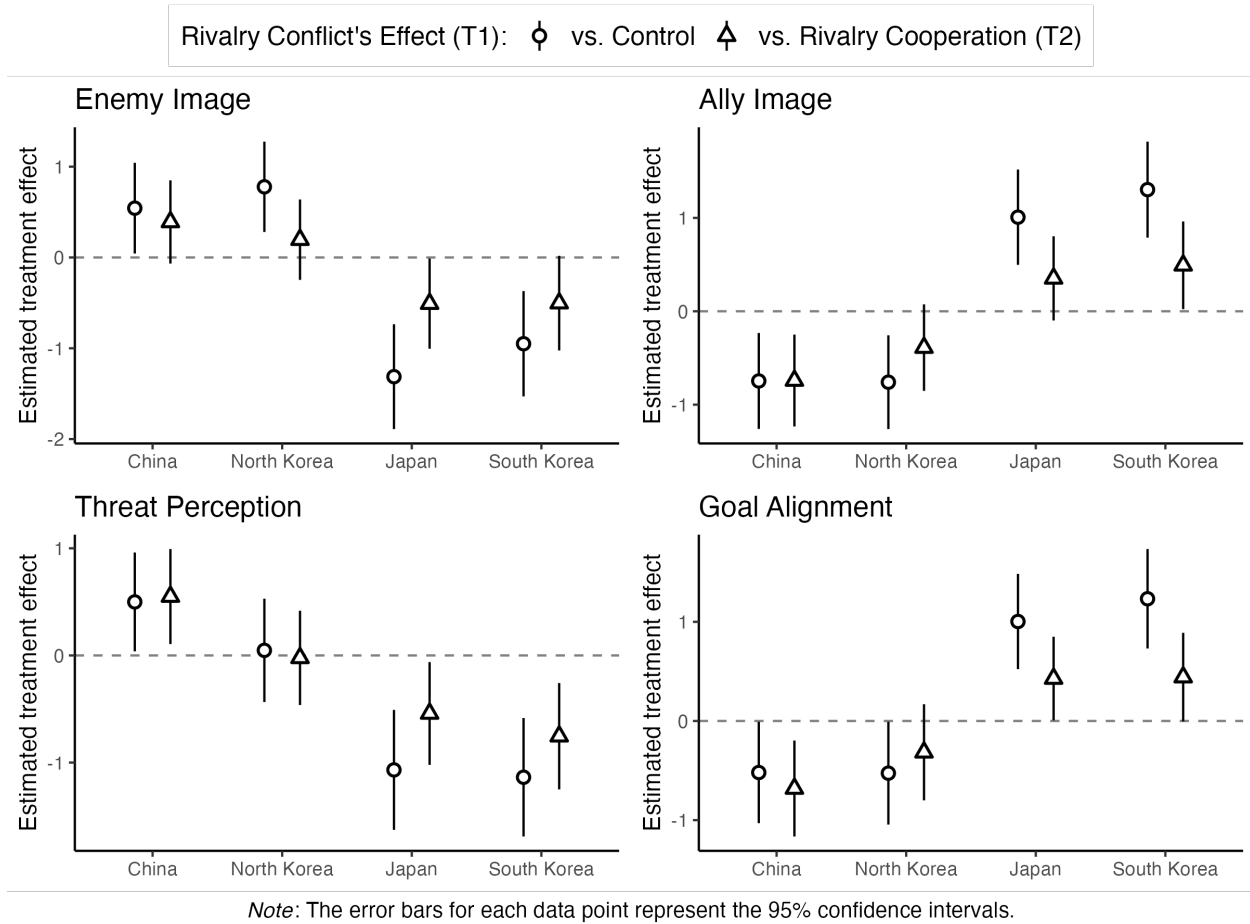


Note: Violin plots show response distributions. Points indicate sample means; error bars represent 95% confidence intervals.

China's enemy-image score by 0.54 points ($p < 0.05$) and threat-perception score by 0.50 points ($p < 0.05$), while reducing China's ally-image score by 0.75 points ($p < 0.01$) and goal-alignment score by 0.52 points ($p < 0.05$). The comparison with the Japan-China cooperation treatment further clarifies that these effects are not driven solely by exposure to the rivalry dyad or to interstate conflicts more generally. Relative to respondents exposed to Japan-China cooperation, those exposed to Japan-China conflict rated China 0.39 points higher on enemy image ($p < 0.1$) and 0.55 points higher on threat perception ($p < 0.05$). They also rated China 0.74 points lower on ally image ($p < 0.01$) and 0.68 points lower on goal alignment ($p < 0.01$).

Moreover, according to the theory, the effects of an overlapping rivalry should extend beyond evaluations of the focal rival and produce broader polarization in ally and enemy images. Consistent with this expectation, [Figure 7](#) shows that the Japan-China conflict treatment affects perceptions of other East Asian countries as well. Relative to the control condition, respondents exposed to the

Figure 7: Treatment Effects of Overlapping Rivalry (Japan-China Rivalry) on American Perceptions of East Asian Countries



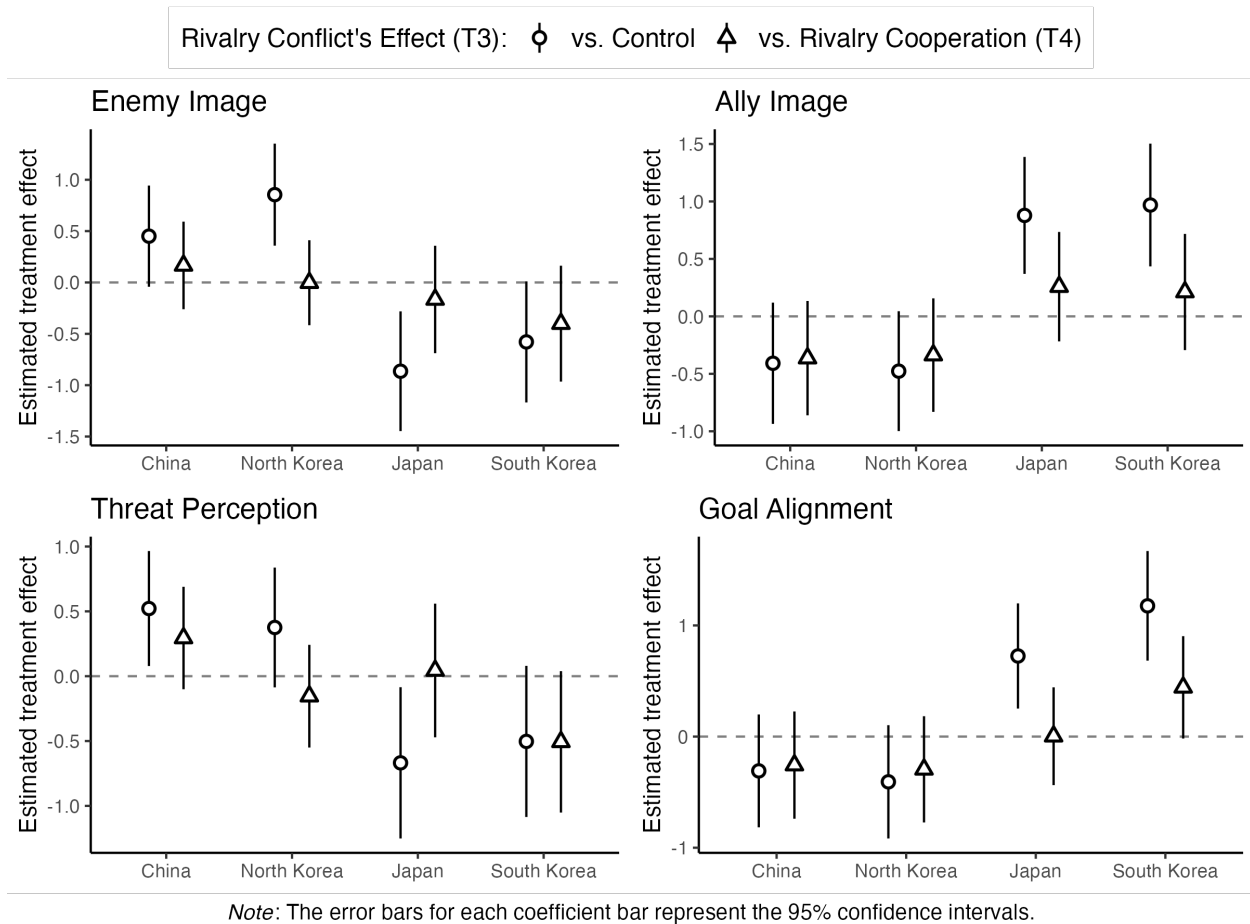
Senkaku/Diaoyu conflict evaluated North Korea more negatively, increasing its enemy-image score by 0.78 points ($p < 0.01$) and reducing its ally-image and goal-alignment scores by 0.76 and 0.53 points, respectively ($p < 0.01$ and $p < 0.05$). By contrast, respondents evaluated Japan and South Korea more positively: the treatment reduced Japan's enemy-image and threat-perception scores by 1.31 and 1.07 points while increasing its ally-image and goal-alignment scores by 1.01 and 1.00 points (all $p < 0.01$). Similarly, it reduced South Korea's enemy-image and threat-perception scores by 0.95 and 1.14 points while increasing its ally-image and goal-alignment scores by 1.30 and 1.23 points (all $p < 0.01$). The direct comparison with the Japan-China cooperation treatment shows a similar, though weaker, pattern: the rivalry conflict improves evaluations of Japan and South Korea

relative to cooperation, while the results for North Korea are less consistent.

Next, the analysis turns to the effects of a parallel rivalry, represented by conflict between South Korea and North Korea. According to [H2A](#), conflict within this parallel rivalry should also worsen Americans' perceptions of China, even though China is not directly involved in the observed interaction. The results provide partial support for this expectation. As shown in [Figure 8](#), respondents exposed to inter-Korean conflict evaluated China more negatively than respondents in the control condition, although the effects are smaller and less consistent than in the Japan-China treatment. Specifically, the conflict treatment on the inter-Korean rivalry increases China's enemy-image score by 0.45 points ($p < 0.1$) and threat-perception score by 0.52 points ($p < 0.05$). It also reduces China's ally-image and goal-alignment scores by 0.41 and 0.31 points, respectively, although these estimates do not reach conventional levels of statistical significance. The direct comparison with the South-North Korea cooperation treatment shows a similar direction of effects—higher enemy image and threat perception, and lower ally image and goal alignment—but these differences are not statistically significant.

My theory suggests that this spillover effect should coincide with a broader polarization of ally and rival images. Consistent with this expectation, [Figure 8](#) shows that the South-North Korea conflict treatment affects perceptions of other East Asian countries as well. Compared to the control condition, respondents exposed to inter-Korean conflict evaluated North Korea more negatively, increasing its enemy-image score by 0.85 points ($p < 0.01$) and reducing its ally-image score by 0.48 points ($p < 0.1$). At the same time, respondents evaluated U.S. allies more favorably: the treatment increased Japan's ally image and goal alignment by 0.88 and 0.73 points, respectively, and South Korea's by 0.97 and 1.18 points (all, $p < 0.01$). Relative to respondents exposed to inter-Korean cooperation, those exposed to inter-Korean conflict rated South Korea lower on threat perception by 0.51 points ($p < 0.1$) and higher on goal alignment by 0.44 points ($p < 0.1$). The same comparison does not produce statistically significant shifts in perceptions of North Korea or Japan, suggesting that the distinction between conflict and cooperation within the parallel rivalry

Figure 8: Treatment Effects of Overlapping Rivalry (Inter-Korean Rivalry) on American Perceptions of East Asian Countries

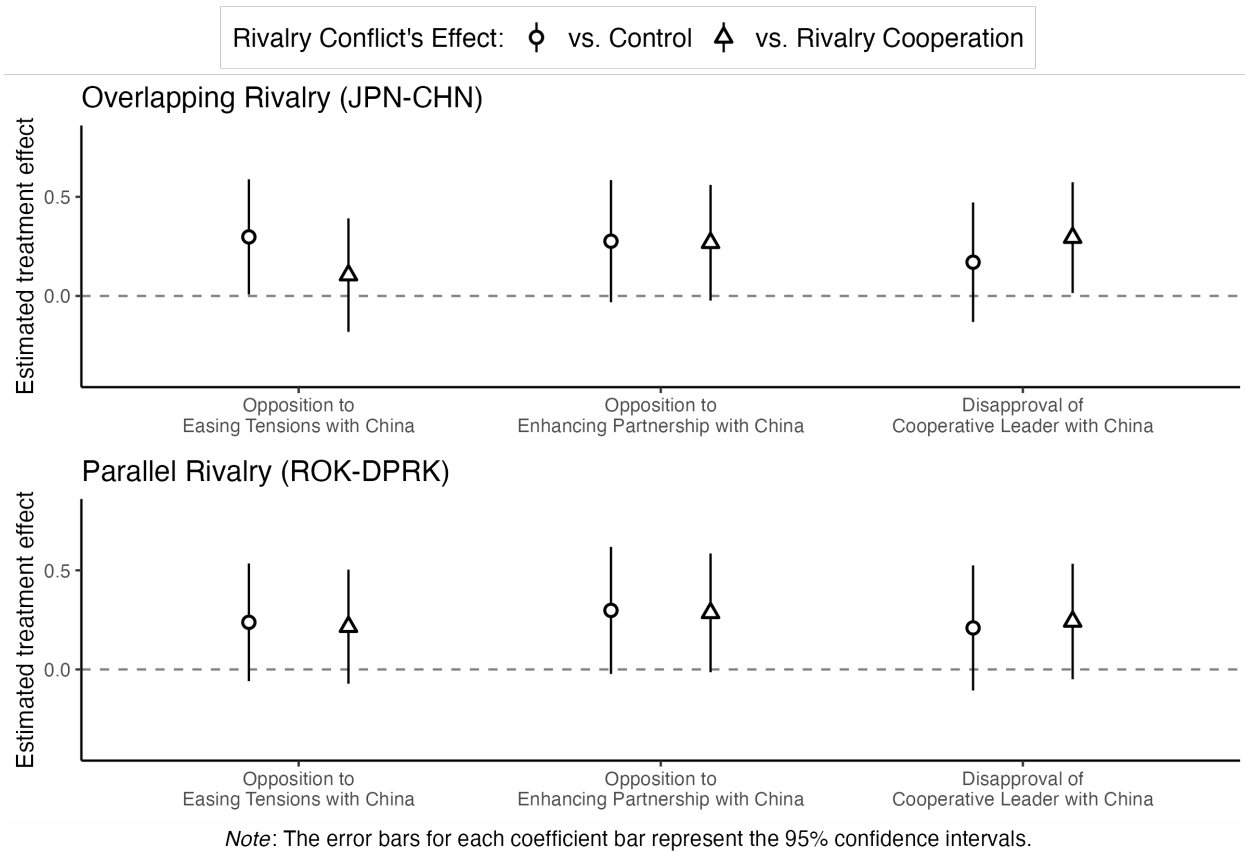


is less pronounced than the comparison between conflict and the control condition.

The weaker effects of the parallel rivalry treatment are consistent with Study I. In both studies, third-party rivalry information has stronger effects when the focal rival is directly involved in the observed interaction than when the effect operates indirectly through a parallel rivalry. In Study I, U.S.-DPRK conflict was more strongly associated with South Korean perceptions of North Korea than with Japanese perceptions of China; similarly, in the experiment, Japan-China conflict directly implicates China, whereas inter-Korean conflict can affect perceptions of China only indirectly through North Korea's association with the broader enemy camp. In Study 2, the smaller effects of the parallel rivalry treatment may also reflect differences in the intensity of the treatment events.

The Japan-China conditions featured a salient territorial dispute over the Diaoyu/Senkaku Islands, while the inter-Korean conditions involved a North Korean drone incursion. Although substantively meaningful, the latter events may have appeared less consequential than territorial confrontation

Figure 9: Treatment Effects of Third-Party Rivalries in East Asia on American Opinion on Cooperation toward China



The final analysis turns to [H1B](#) and [H2B](#), which examine whether conflict in third-party rivalries reduces American support for cooperation with China. As shown in [Figure 9](#), both the overlapping rivalry and parallel rivalry treatments tend to increase opposition to conciliatory policies toward China, although the effects are modest. In the overlapping rivalry condition, exposure to Japan-China conflict increases opposition to easing tensions with China by 0.30 points ($p < 0.05$) and opposition to enhancing partnership with China by 0.28 points ($p < 0.1$), relative to the control condition. When compared directly to the Japan-China cooperation treatment, the conflict treatment

also increases opposition to enhancing partnership by 0.27 points ($p < 0.1$) and disapproval of a cooperative leader by 0.29 points ($p < 0.05$). The parallel rivalry treatment shows a similar but weaker pattern: inter-Korean conflict increases opposition to enhancing partnership with China by 0.30 points relative to the control condition ($p < 0.1$), and by 0.29 points relative to inter-Korean cooperation ($p < 0.1$).

As shown in Appendix 2, I conduct additional analyses to assess the robustness of the experimental findings. First, I conduct balance checks across the treatment conditions and find no systematic differences in pre-treatment covariates. Second, I re-estimate the main models while including respondents' demographic characteristics, including gender, age, education, income, partisanship, and ideology. The main results remain largely unchanged, suggesting that the main findings are not driven by compositional differences across treatment groups.

Conclusion

This paper argues that public opinion on peace with a foreign adversary depends not only on dynamics within the focal rivalry dyad, but also on the wider network of rivalries surrounding it. When citizens experience hostility in a third-party rivalry between allied and adversarial states, such conflict can sharpen perceived ally-enemy boundaries, reinforce the enemy image of the focal rival, and increase resistance to rapprochement. Evidence from East Asia supports this argument. In Study I, conflict between the United States and North Korea was associated with stronger anti-North Korean sentiment in South Korea and with more negative views of China in Japan. In Study II, experimental exposure to conflict in the Japan-China rivalry increased Americans' enemy image of China and reduced support for cooperative policy toward China, while conflict in the inter-Korean rivalry produced similar but weaker effects. Together, these findings show that public opinion on peace is embedded in networked rivalries: citizens evaluate adversaries not only through the focal rivalry itself, but also through conflict and cooperation unfolding in other rivalry dyads within the wider

international environment.

These findings shed light on the puzzle introduced at the outset: why similar peace initiatives by Presidents Roh Moo-hyun and Moon Jae-in generated sharply different public responses. Although both leaders elicited cooperation from North Korea, South Koreans interpreted these efforts not only through bilateral relations, but also through signals from third-party states. In Roh's case, the post-9/11 security climate, especially the U.S. War on Terror, reinforced North Korea's enemy image. Even though North Korea's direct threat to South Korea had not substantially changed, South Korea's principal ally framed Pyongyang as part of the "Axis of Evil" ([Cha, 2002](#)), making North Korea appear more hostile and less trustworthy to South Koreans. By contrast, Moon pursued engagement in a more favorable international environment, as the Trump administration's high-profile summit diplomacy with Kim Jong-un signaled a symbolic thaw in U.S.–North Korea relations and created a broader context more supportive of dialogue ([Brookings Institution, 2018](#)). This shift in the ally-rival relationship likely softened North Korea's adversarial image among South Koreans, making Moon's peace efforts appear more credible and more consistent with the prevailing international environment.

The findings make three contributions to the study of international security, political psychology, and public opinion on peace in East Asia. First, the paper advances research on public opinion and rapprochement by moving beyond dyadic models of adversary signaling. Existing studies emphasize how cooperative signals, public predispositions, and leadership cues within rivalry dyads shape support for peace ([Kertzer et al., 2020](#); [Mattes & Weeks, 2019](#); [S. J. Kim, 2021](#); [Mattes & Weeks, 2022](#); [Fu & Lee, 2024](#); [Han, 2025](#)). This paper shows that extra-dyadic interactions also matter: conflict in third-party rivalries between allied and adversarial states can reinforce the focal rival's enemy image and increase resistance to peace. Second, this research contributes to network approaches in international relations by explaining how networked rivalries enter public perception. Existing research shows that rivalries are embedded in wider structures of allies, enemies, and indirect ties that shape conflict, cooperation, and rivalry termination ([Maoz et al., 2007](#); [Valeriano](#)

& Powers, 2016; B. K. Lee, 2022). Building on this literature, the paper shows that citizens may interpret third-party conflict as evidence of broader intergroup confrontation, thereby reinforcing resistance to rapprochement within the focal rivalry. Third, the paper provides multi-method evidence by combining large-scale social media analysis with an original survey experiment. Whereas much of the existing research on public opinion in East Asian security relies primarily on survey-based measures (Mattes & Weeks, 2019; Myrick, 2021; Kertzer et al., 2019; Xu, 2025; B. K. Lee, 2026; Han et al., 2026), this paper uses Twitter data to capture naturally occurring public discourse and pairs it with experimental evidence to identify the causal effects of third-party rivalry cues.

This study offers two policy-relevant implications for leaders seeking to sustain public support for rapprochement in East Asia. First, U.S. efforts to manage competition with China cannot rely on bilateral diplomacy alone. Because American perceptions of China are embedded in a wider network of East Asian rivalries, signals from allies such as Japan and South Korea can either harden or soften China's enemy image among the U.S. public. Multilateral efforts that visibly include these allies—such as coordinated regional dialogues, crisis-management mechanisms, or joint statements supporting diplomatic engagement—may therefore help create domestic political space for U.S.-China de-escalation. Second, for South Korean and Japanese leaders pursuing de-escalation with North Korea and China, respectively, domestic backlash may depend not only on bilateral diplomacy but also on the broader framing of U.S. foreign policy. A U.S.-led democracy-versus-autocracy frame can strengthen ally-enemy distinctions and make conciliation with North Korea or China appear inconsistent with the broader coalition structure. By contrast, a more transactional U.S. approach may weaken this cleavage, making North Korea or China less likely to be interpreted through a rigid enemy image and creating greater domestic room for engagement.

While this paper offers a novel theoretical account of how networked rivalries shape public opinion on peace, several important directions for future research emerge from its scope conditions. One such condition is the assumption that individuals, particularly in the context of international rivalry, tend to rely on simplified binary categorizations of foreign states—as either allies or ene-

mies. While this framework provides analytic clarity and supports the modeling of image-based opinion updating, it may understate the complexity of real-world public perceptions. In practice, individuals may hold more ambivalent or multidimensional views of foreign states, distinguishing, for example, between economic cooperation and military threat, or between a regime and its people. Future work could address this limitation by developing more nuanced measures of national image that account for issue-specific or conditional perceptions, and by exploring alternative categorizations beyond the ally–enemy dichotomy. In addition, this study focuses primarily on inter-group interactions—those between states aligned with opposing blocs—as the source of image polarization. Yet, interactions within alliance networks may also shape public perceptions in meaningful ways. Alliance cohesion can strengthen group identity and harden enemy images, while alliance fractures may weaken this unity and soften public support for rivalry. Future research should examine whether and how such intra-group shape the stability of ally–enemy distinctions and influence public attitudes in peace.

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